



Fresh dawn: After a 24-year absence from the World Cup, Türkiye returns with Real Madrid star Arda Guler carrying the hopes of a nation dreaming of a deep run. REUTERS

Weah, Chris Richards and Tyler Adams have all acquitted themselves well at the highest levels of European football.

If the USA is to produce its finest World Cup performance, though, it must first navigate a Group D that promises to be fiercely competitive, even if it lacks the tournament's traditional heavyweights.

Among the challengers is Türkiye, which is making its first World Cup appearance since a remarkable run to third place in 2002. Coached by Vincenzo Montella, who led the side to the quarterfinals of UEFA Euro 2024, it bounced back from a 6-0 drubbing by Spain to qualify efficiently through the UEFA playoffs.

It has plenty of quality at its disposal. Veteran Inter Milan midfielder Hakan Calhanoglu will provide experience and control in the middle of the park, while the creative young duo of Kenan Yildiz (Juventus) and Arda Guler (Real Madrid), neither of whom was born the last time Türkiye appeared at a World Cup, could prove decisive in attack.

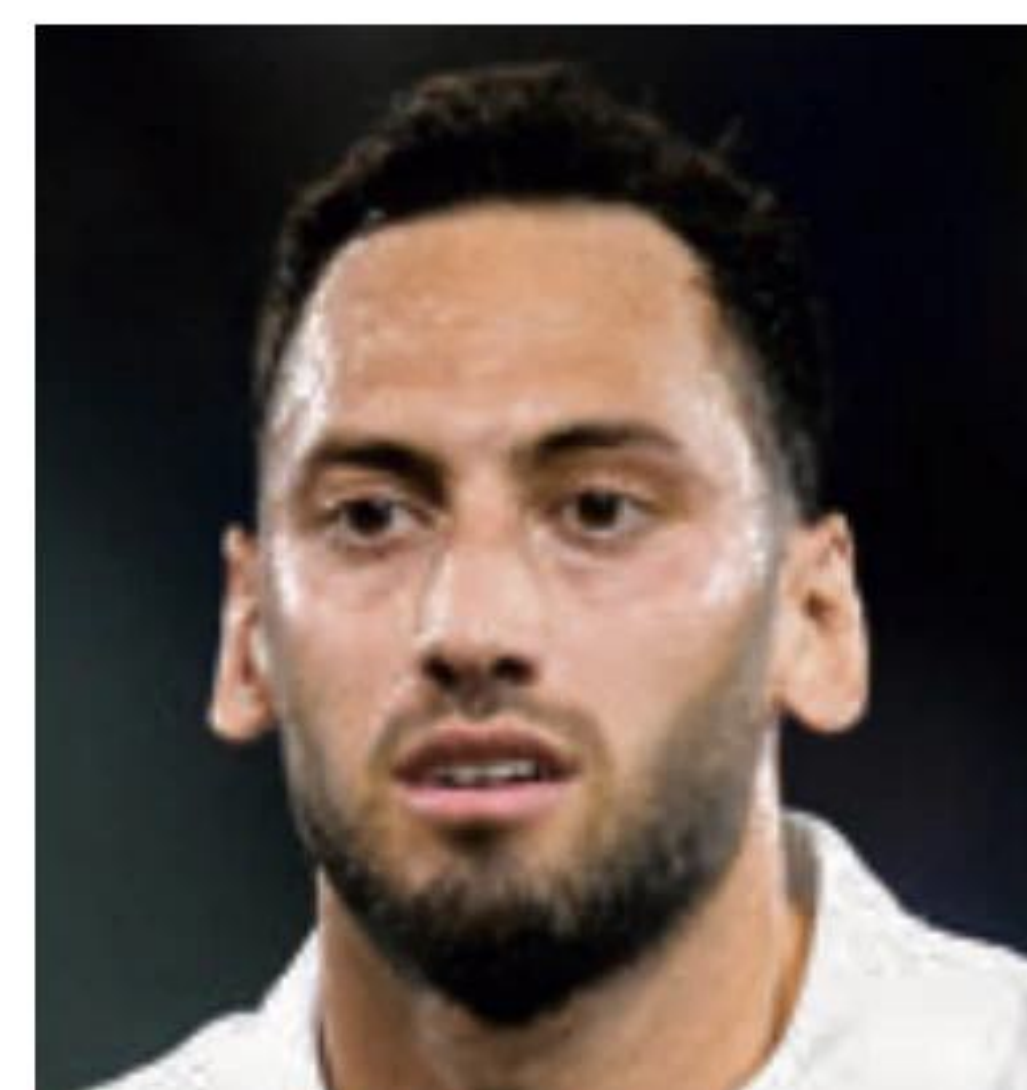
Also returning to the World Cup stage is Paraguay, back for the first time since reaching the quarterfinals in 2010. Gustavo Alfaro's side qualified through one of the additional CONMEBOL slots created by the tournament's expanded format and will prove a difficult opponent for any team in the group.

ON THE RADAR



Christian Pulisic (USA)

Christian Pulisic has been synonymous with the USA's success in recent years and, with home support behind him, the USA captain will be eager to use his dribbling and creativity to inspire his side for a deep run.



Hakan Calhanoglu (Türkiye)

Only two players have made more appearances for Türkiye than Hakan Calhanoglu, and the 32-year-old will finally make his World Cup debut in 2026. Renowned for his passing range and dead-ball expertise, Calhanoglu will be expected to dictate proceedings from midfield.